

recent savings on diapers. Pictures of subscribers with their stacks of free boxes of crackers, carefully arranged bottles of shampoos, and babies nestled in their car seats surrounded by a mountain of free formula or diapers, left me with a feeling of kinship, as if we were all one big family participating in the same fun hobby. Every day my mailbox was full of letters and thick envelopes stuffed with coupons. I impatiently waited for the refund magazines to arrive so I could see what new offers were out or what the current hot coupon was that I might not have gotten in my own coupon inserts, but could trade for.

Enter the era of the Internet, and the end of the waiting game.

I didn't jump on the Internet bandwagon until 1998. At that time I was helping my husband get a bookstore off the ground, as well as selling books to homeschoolers through a list I mailed out every six weeks. I'd noticed that several vintage children's books were a hot commodity among my clients. Books by authors such as Lois Lenski, Maud Hart Lovelace, Lenora Mattingly Weber, and Janet Lambert were snatched up so quickly that I couldn't keep them in stock. One of my customers, a homeschooling mother from New York, telephoned me every month with her long order. The first thing I did when I got online was to peruse the auction site I'd heard mentioned by other booksellers—eBay. It only took me a few minutes to discern that my top-buyer was selling the very books I'd sold her, for ten times the price!

The second thing I did, after signing up for my own eBay account, was to investigate the websites of my two favorite refund magazines. The message boards and forums introduced me to a whole new world of shopping, with